realms, with the overt and covert backing of several states, including Iran, Saudi Arabia, and Pakistan.

After the defeat of the Soviet Union in Afghanistan in the late 1980s, the mujahideen's attention turned to other places including Kashmir and Chechnya. But another precipitating moment resulted from the first Gulf War of 1990–91, during which the United States ousted Saddam Hussein's Iraqi forces from Kuwait. The increased presence of US forces in West Asia —and especially in Saudi Arabia—after the Gulf War became a point of contention. It became a focus for Osama bin Laden, a wealthy Saudi who had been peripherally involved with the Afghan mujahideen and who founded an Islamist terrorist group known as al-Qaeda (or 'the base'). Expelled from Saudi Arabia for his opposition to the royal family, bin Laden went on to wage global jihad against the United States, Israel, and others from a haven in Sudan and later from Afghanistan.

What followed is well-known. After attacks against US embassies in Kenya and Tanzania in 1995, and an American naval vessel in Yemen in 2000, al-Qaeda used passenger airplanes to destroy the twin towers of the World Trade Center in New York and part of the Pentagon in Washington on 11 September 2001. [10] This was the most deadly attack on US soil after the World War II, and by hitting a major financial capital and nerve centre it affected citizens and interests of many other countries, including India. The United States announced a 'global war on terror' and by the end of the year had gone to war in Afghanistan, toppling the Taliban government that sheltered bin Laden and al-Qaeda. Al-Qaeda's leadership spent many years in hiding. In December 2001, an attack by Jaish-e-Mohammed on the Indian Parliament, and Pakistan's movement of forces from its western border to its east, facilitated bin Laden's to escape from Tora Bora in Afghanistan into Pakistan. He eventually made his way to the Pakistani town of Abbottabad, where a secure home was constructed for him. Finally, after the US intelligence agencies refocused on the hunt for bin Laden, his location was identified and in 2011, US special operations forces killed him in a daring raid. [11]